

Word family: **tear / tears / tore / torn / tearing / tearful / tearfully / tearfulness**

Base word: tear

Verb forms: **tear / tears / tore / torn / tearing**

Important pronunciation split: **tear** has **two different pronunciations and meanings**:

* **tear** /tɛə(r)/ — **撕裂；扯破**

* **tear** /tɪə(r)/ — **眼淚**

These are best treated as **homographs**: same spelling, different pronunciation, different lexical meaning.

Related forms:

* **torn** (adj./participle) — 撕裂的；破的；內心矛盾的

* **tearful** (adj.) — 含淚的；哭泣的

* **tearfully** (adv.) — 含淚地

* **tearfulness** (n.) — 哭泣；容易流淚的狀態

Useful extensions:

* **tear paper / fabric**

* **tear something apart**

* **tear something open**

* **tear something off**

* **tear something up**

* **tear down**

* **tear through**

* **tear into**

* **tear yourself away**

* **be torn between A and B**

* **tear a muscle / ligament**

* **in tears**

* **burst into tears**

* **move someone to tears**

* **bring tears to someone's eyes**

* **fight back tears**

* **hold back tears**

* **tears of joy**

* **tear-jerker**

A. **tear /tɛə(r)/** — 撕裂；扯破

1. **tear something (撕 ; 扯破) — 撕破 ; 撕裂**

This is the core physical verb sense.

Practice 1

> Be careful not to **tear the paper**.

小心不要**撕破那張紙**。

Practice 2

> She accidentally **tore her dress** on a nail.

她的裙子不小心被釘子**勾破 / 扯破了**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****tear something = 用力拉扯 , 使紙張、布料等裂開或破掉****

2. **something tears — 裂開 ; 撕裂**

Intransitive use.

Practice 1

> This fabric **tears** easily.

這種布料很容易**撕裂**。

Practice 2

> The bag **tore** when I lifted it.

我把袋子提起時 , 它**裂開了**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****tear = 某種物料因拉扯或受力而裂開****

3. **tear something in half / into pieces — 把某物撕成兩半 / 碎片**

Practice 1

> He **tore the letter in half**.

他把信**撕成兩半**。

Practice 2

> She **tore the paper into small pieces**.

她把紙**撕成小片**。

MCQ-ready definition:

tear something in half/into pieces = 把某物撕開成較小部分

4. **tear something open — 撕開**

Practice 1

> He **tore the envelope open**.

他把信封**撕開了**。

Practice 2

> The child **tore the present open** excitedly.

那個孩子興奮地把禮物包裝**撕開**。

MCQ-ready definition:

tear something open = 用撕扯方式把封閉的東西打開

5. **tear something off — 撕下；扯下**

Practice 1

> She **tore a page off** the notebook.

她從筆記簿上**撕下一頁**。

Practice 2

> He **tore the label off** the bottle.

他把瓶上的標籤**撕掉**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****tear something off = 用力撕扯，把某物從原來連接的位置弄下來****

6. ****tear something up — 撕碎****

Practice 1

> He ****tore up the letter**** after reading it.

他看完信後把它**撕碎了**。

Practice 2

> She ****tore the old document up**** and threw it away.

她把舊文件**撕碎**後丟掉。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****tear something up = 把紙張等撕成很多小塊****

7. ****tear something apart — 撕開；扯碎****

Literal use.

Practice 1

> The dog ****tore the toy apart****.

那隻狗把玩具**扯爛了**。

Practice 2

> The machine ****tore the fabric apart****.

那部機器把布料**撕裂了**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****tear something apart = 用很大力把某物撕開、扯碎或破壞****

8. **tear something apart** (figurative) — 摧毀；使分裂

Practice 1

> The conflict **tore** the family apart.

那場衝突令那個家庭四分五裂。

Practice 2

> The scandal **tore** the organization apart.

那宗醜聞令該組織嚴重分裂。

MCQ-ready definition:

tear something apart = 嚴重破壞一個群體、關係或組織，使其分裂

9. **tear yourself away from something** — 勉強離開；捨不得離開

Practice 1

> I couldn't **tear** myself away from the book.

我簡直捨不得放下那本書。

Practice 2

> She finally **tore** herself away from the television.

她終於勉強離開電視前。

MCQ-ready definition:

tear yourself away from something = 因為非常投入或喜歡某事，而很難強迫自己離開

10. **tear through somewhere** — 飛快穿過；猛衝

Practice 1

> The car **tore** through the streets.

那輛車在街道上飛馳而過。

Practice 2

> The dog **tore through the garden**.

那隻狗在花園裏**狂奔而過**。

MCQ-ready definition:

tear through somewhere = 以很快、很猛烈的方式穿過某地

11. **tear through something (快速處理 / 消耗) — 很快完成 / 用掉**

Practice 1

> He **tore through the book** in one evening.

他一個晚上就**很快看完了那本書**。

Practice 2

> The children **tore through the food**.

孩子們很快就把食物**吃光了**。

MCQ-ready definition:

tear through something = 以很快速度完成、閱讀、吃掉或處理大量東西

12. **tear into someone — 嚴厲責罵 / 猛烈抨擊某人**

Informal.

Practice 1

> The coach **tore into the players** after the match.

比賽後，教練**狠狠責罵了球員**。

Practice 2

> She **tore into him** for arriving late again.

她因他再次遲到而**狠狠地罵了他一頓**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****tear into someone = 以非常強烈、激烈的方式批評或責罵某人****

13. ****tear into food — 狼吞虎嚥地吃****

Informal.

Practice 1

> The hungry children ****tore into the pizza****.

肚子餓的孩子們開始****狼吞虎嚥地吃薄餅****。

Practice 2

> He ****tore into his dinner**** as soon as he sat down.

他一坐下便****大口大口地吃晚飯****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****tear into food = 很快、很有力地開始吃東西****

14. ****tear down — 拆掉；拆毀****

Practice 1

> They plan to ****tear down the old building****.

他們計劃****拆掉那座舊建築****。

Practice 2

> The wall was ****torn down**** last year.

那道牆去年被****拆除了****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****tear something down = 把建築物、牆等拆毀****

15. **tear down someone (figurative) — 貶低；打擊某人**

Practice 1

> Good leaders don't **tear people down**.

好的領導者不會**貶低別人**。

Practice 2

> Constant criticism can **tear a person down**.

持續的批評可能會**打擊一個人的自信和精神**。

MCQ-ready definition:

tear someone down = 透過批評、羞辱等方式打擊某人的自信或形象

16. **tear a muscle / ligament — 拉傷 / 撕裂肌肉或韌帶**

Practice 1

> He **tore a muscle** in his leg.

他的腿部**肌肉撕裂了**。

Practice 2

> She **tore a ligament** while playing football.

她踢足球時**撕裂了韌帶**。

MCQ-ready definition:

tear a muscle/ligament = 使肌肉或韌帶組織因受力而部分或完全撕裂

17. **torn (衣物 / 材料) — 撕破的；裂開的**

Practice 1

> He was wearing a **torn shirt**.

他穿着一件**撕破了的恤衫**。

Practice 2

> The book had several ****torn pages****.

那本書有幾頁****被撕破了****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****torn = 因撕扯而破裂或受損的****

18. ****be torn between A and B — 在兩者之間難以取捨；內心矛盾****

A major figurative extension.

Practice 1

> I'm ****torn between staying here and moving abroad****.

我在****留下來和移居外國之間難以取捨****。

Practice 2

> She was ****torn between loyalty and ambition****.

她在忠誠與抱負之間****內心非常矛盾****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****be torn between A and B = 面對兩個選擇或感受時，因兩邊都有吸引力而難以決定****

19. ****be torn about something — 對某事十分矛盾****

Practice 1

> I'm still ****torn about whether to accept the offer****.

我對是否接受那個提議仍然****很矛盾****。

Practice 2

> He felt ****torn about leaving his family****.

對於離開家人這件事，他感到****十分掙扎****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****be torn about something = 對某個決定或情況有互相衝突的感受****

B. ****tear /tɪə(r)/**** — 眼淚

20. ****a tear (眼淚) — 一滴眼淚****

This is the core noun meaning of the second pronunciation.

Practice 1

> A ****tear**** rolled down her cheek.

一滴****眼淚****沿着她的臉頰流下來。

Practice 2

> He wiped away a ****tear****.

他擦去了一滴****眼淚****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****a tear = 眼睛因情緒、刺激等產生的一滴液體，即眼淚****

21. ****tears (眼淚) — 淚水；眼淚****

Usually plural when talking about crying.

Practice 1

> ****Tears**** filled her eyes.

她眼中充滿了****淚水****。

Practice 2

> He had ****tears**** running down his face.

他的臉上流着****眼淚****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****tears = 因哭泣、情緒或眼睛受刺激而流出的淚水****

22. **in tears — 哭着；淚流滿面**

Practice 1

> She left the room **in tears**.

她**哭着**離開房間。

Practice 2

> He was **in tears** after hearing the news.

他聽到消息後**淚流滿面**。

MCQ-ready definition:

in tears = 正在哭泣或因情緒強烈而滿眼淚水

23. **burst into tears — 突然哭起來**

You just met this under **burst**.

Practice 1

> The child **burst into tears**.

那個孩子突然**哭了起來**。

Practice 2

> She **burst into tears** when she saw him.

她看到他時突然**哭了出來**。

MCQ-ready definition:

burst into tears = 因強烈情緒而突然開始哭泣

24. **be close to tears / on the verge of tears — 快要哭了**

Practice 1

> She looked **close to tears**.

她看起來**快要哭了**。

Practice 2

> He was **on the verge of tears** after the argument.

爭吵後，他**幾乎要哭出來**。

MCQ-ready definition:

be close to tears = 情緒強烈到幾乎要開始哭泣

25. **fight back tears — 強忍眼淚**

Practice 1

> She **fought back tears** during the speech.

演講期間，她一直**強忍眼淚**。

Practice 2

> He **fought back tears** as he said goodbye.

他道別時**努力忍住眼淚**。

MCQ-ready definition:

fight back tears = 努力控制自己，不讓眼淚流出來

26. **hold back tears — 忍住眼淚**

Very similar to **fight back tears**.

Practice 1

> She could barely **hold back her tears**.

她幾乎**忍不住眼淚**。

Practice 2

> He tried to **hold back tears** during the ceremony.

儀式期間，他努力**忍住眼淚**。

MCQ-ready definition:

hold back tears = 控制自己的情緒，阻止眼淚流出

27. **move someone to tears** — 感動得令某人流淚

Practice 1

> The speech **moved her to tears**.

那篇演講令她**感動落淚**。

Practice 2

> His kindness **moved me to tears**.

他的善良令我**感動得流下眼淚**。

MCQ-ready definition:

move someone to tears = 令某人因強烈感動而哭泣

28. **bring tears to someone's eyes** — 令某人眼泛淚光

Practice 1

> The memory **brought tears to her eyes**.

那段回憶令她**眼泛淚光**。

Practice 2

> The song always **brings tears to my eyes**.

那首歌總會令我**眼眶泛淚**。

MCQ-ready definition:

bring tears to someone's eyes = 令某人因感動、悲傷等而幾乎或真的流淚

29. **tears of joy — 喜極而泣的眼淚；喜悅之淚**

Practice 1

> She cried **tears of joy** when she heard the result.

她聽到結果後**喜極而泣**。

Practice 2

> His parents were in **tears of joy**.

他的父母流下了**喜悅的淚水**。

MCQ-ready definition:

tears of joy = 因極度開心或感動而流下的眼淚

30. **tears of sadness / frustration — 悲傷 / 挫折的眼淚**

Practice 1

> She cried **tears of frustration**.

她因挫折而**流下眼淚**。

Practice 2

> His eyes filled with **tears of sadness**.

他的眼中充滿**悲傷的淚水**。

MCQ-ready definition:

tears of X = 因某種強烈情緒而流下的眼淚

31. **cry yourself to tears / reduce someone to tears — 哭得很厲害 / 把某人弄哭**

Practice 1

> The harsh criticism **reduced her to tears**.

嚴厲的批評把她**弄哭了**。

Practice 2

> He was **reduced to tears** by the pressure.

壓力大得令他**哭了出來**。

MCQ-ready definition:

reduce someone to tears = 令某人因悲傷、壓力或痛苦而哭泣

32. **tearful — 含淚的；快哭的**

Practice 1

> She gave him a **tearful goodbye**.

她**含着淚**向他道別。

Practice 2

> The child looked **tearful** after losing his toy.

那個孩子弄丟玩具後看起來**眼淚汪汪**。

MCQ-ready definition:

tearful = 因悲傷、感動等而眼中有淚或正在哭泣的

33. **tearfully — 含淚地**

Practice 1

> She **tearfully** thanked everyone for their support.

她**含淚地**感謝大家的支持。

Practice 2

> He **tearfully** said goodbye.

他**眼含淚水地**道別。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****tearfully = 以眼中含淚或正在哭泣的方式****

34. ****tear-jerker — 催淚作品****

Informal.

Practice 1

> The film is a real ****tear-jerker****.

這部電影真的很****催淚****。

Practice 2

> I wasn't expecting the story to be such a ****tear-jerker****.

我沒想到這個故事會這麼****催人淚下****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****tear-jerker = 故意或很容易令人感動落淚的電影、故事等作品****

Important distinction 1: ****tear /tɛə(r)/ vs tear /tɪə(r)/****

This is the most important thing about the word.

****tear /tɛə(r)/****

verb/noun connected with ****ripping****

> ****tear the paper****

****撕紙****

****tear /tɪə(r)/****

noun connected with ****crying****

> a ****tear**** in her eye

她眼中的一滴****眼淚****

Same spelling, different pronunciation and meaning.

Important distinction 2: **tear** vs **rip**

Both can mean **撕裂**.

tear

neutral and broad

> **tear the paper**

撕紙

rip

often sounds more forceful or sudden

> **rip the package open**

猛地撕開包裝

They overlap heavily, but **rip** often feels more energetic or violent.

Important distinction 3: **tear** vs **break**

tear

best with flexible or fibrous material:

- * paper
- * cloth
- * skin
- * muscle
- * ligament

break

best with hard/rigid objects:

- * glass
- * chair

* stick
* bone

So:

> **tear paper**

not normally **break paper**

and:

> **break a glass**

not normally **tear a glass**

Important distinction 4: **tore vs torn**

tore

simple past

> She **tore** the paper.

她撕破了紙。

torn

past participle/adjective

> She has **torn** the paper.

她已把紙撕破。

> a **torn** shirt

一件破了的恤衫

So:

tear → tore → torn

Important distinction 5: **torn literal vs figurative**

Literal

> a **torn** page

一頁**撕破了的**紙

Figurative

> I'm **torn between two choices**.

我在兩個選擇之間**很矛盾**。

The figurative image is:

something pulled in two directions

→ **a person emotionally pulled in two directions**

Important distinction 6: **tear up vs tearful**

These are completely different despite sharing the spelling **tear**.

tear up /tɛə(r)/

= 撕碎

> **tear up the letter**

把信撕碎

tear up /tɛə(r)/ in some informal uses

= 眼中泛淚

> His eyes **teared up**.

他的眼睛**泛起淚光**。

This second verbal use is especially common in American English.

35. **tear up (eyes) — 眼睛泛淚**

Especially AmE.

Practice 1

> Her eyes **teared up** when she heard the news.

她聽到消息後**眼眶泛淚**。

Practice 2

> I always **tear up** at the end of that film.

我每次看到那部電影的結尾都會**眼泛淚光**。

MCQ-ready definition:

tear up = 眼睛開始充滿淚水，快要哭出來

This is pronounced from **tear** = 眼淚, not **tear** = 撕裂.

Important distinction 7: **burst into tears** vs **tear up**

burst into tears

= actually start crying suddenly

tear up

= eyes fill with tears; you may or may not fully cry

> She **teared up**.

她眼眶泛淚。

> She **burst into tears**.

她突然哭了起來。

So **burst into tears** is stronger.

Important distinction 8: **in tears** vs **tearful**

in tears

usually means actively crying.

tearful

can mean crying or simply close to crying.

> She was **in tears**.

她正在哭。

> She looked **tearful**.

她看起來眼淚汪汪 / 快哭了。

Important distinction 9: **tear apart vs break apart**

tear apart

often implies ripping force or severe emotional/social destruction.

break apart

broader: separate into pieces or components.

> The argument **tore the family apart**.

爭執令家庭四分五裂。

This phrase is much more idiomatic than **broke the family apart** in this sense.

Important distinction 10: **tear down vs knock down**

For buildings:

tear down

especially AmE; deliberately demolish.

knock down

very common in BrE and general English.

> They ****tore down / knocked down**** the old building.

他們拆除了舊建築。

Family-extension note

****Tear**** is especially valuable for your polysemy project because it actually contains ****two** separate lexical words under one spelling******:

1. ****tear /tɛə(r)/****

Core concept: ****ripping / pulling apart****

This develops into:

- * tear paper
- * tear something apart
- * tear down a building
- * tear a muscle
- * be torn between choices
- * tear through somewhere

2. ****tear /tɪə(r)/****

Core concept: ****liquid from the eye****

This develops into:

- * tears
- * in tears
- * burst into tears
- * tears of joy
- * move someone to tears
- * tearful
- * tear up

This is not merely one word with many contextual translations. The two core ****tear**** words differ in both ****pronunciation and lexical meaning****, so they should be explicitly separated in learner materials.

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea
-----	-----	-----
tear paper /tɛə(r)/	撕紙	rip
fabric tears	布料裂開	split
tear in half	撕成兩半	divide by ripping
tear open	撕開	open by ripping
tear off	撕下	remove by ripping
tear up	撕碎	rip into pieces
tear apart	撕碎 / 摧毀	pull apart
tear family apart	令家庭分裂	figurative destruction
tear through	飛快穿過 / 快速處理	forceful speed
tear into someone	狠狠責罵	attack verbally
tear down	拆毀	demolish
tear a muscle	肌肉撕裂	tissue injury
torn shirt	撕破的恤衫	damaged
torn between A and B	在 A、B 之間難以取捨	conflicted
a tear /tɪə(r)/	一滴眼淚	eye liquid
tears	淚水	crying
in tears	哭着；淚流滿面	crying state
burst into tears	突然哭起來	sudden crying
fight back tears	強忍眼淚	suppress crying
hold back tears	忍住眼淚	restrain tears
move someone to tears	感動得落淚	emotional crying
bring tears to someone's eyes	令某人眼泛淚光	provoke tears
tears of joy	喜悅之淚	happy crying
tearful	含淚的；快哭的	full of tears
tearfully	含淚地	crying manner
tear up /tɪə(r)/	眼泛淚光	eyes fill with tears
tear-jerker	催淚作品	causes tears

Core takeaway

The crucial thing to memorize is:

****tear** /tɛə(r)/ → 撕裂**

> She ****tore** the paper**.

她把紙撕破了。

****tear** /tɪə(r)/ → 眼淚**

> A ****tear**** rolled down her cheek.

一滴眼淚沿着她的臉頰流下來。

And for your Leo passage, the relevant expression from the previous sentence is:

> **burst into tears**

where **tears** means **眼淚**, not the ripping sense.